CHAPTER 6

THE LAST DANCE – DAY TWO

11 July 2024, 11:00am

ENGLAND vs WEST INDIES, 1st Test, *Lord's – Day 2*

West Indies 121 & 79/6; England 371

In the second innings, with the initial fuss dispersed, something clicks. This morning, I have really enjoyed myself. Like at Southport, it's as if I've suddenly been able to re-access all the balls from the past, every different me that has bowled for England, all the different skills and separate evolutions inside me, ready to be called upon with every ball I choose to bowl.

The ball is not swinging at first, so when faced with Kraigg Brathwaite, I know I have to try to do something off the pitch first to keep him honest. I'm moving the ball off the seam, up the famous slope, concentrating on a certain area, allowing him to watch it move. Brathwaite is a stubborn, disciplined cricketer, so I know again I must be patient and wait. The lacquer starts to come off the ball and it starts to swing a little, just a tiny bit, giving him something to think about. With both seam and swing now in his mind, I hold the shiny side of the ball to move like an inswinger but grip the ball as a wobble seam delivery. He tries to track the ball, but with the seam scrambled, it's harder for him to read. It swings towards him, tracing in and spearing itself at him, before then nipping back sharply to bowl him, down the slope, through the gate between bat and pad. My 702nd Test wicket is a carbon copy of my 500th. That one was Brathwaite too.

There was another too. Alick Athanaze has shown courage and discipline for the West Indies and, grinding my teeth and relishing the call